Faculty Connection, Belonging, and Structured Support as Predictors of Student Retention, Persistence, and Graduation: An Evidence Review for Evaluating Faculty-Led Skills Coaching in Online Counseling Education

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Pre-Draft Research Framing

Research Plan

This whitepaper uses a structured review approach to answer a practical institutional question: whether a faculty-led skills coaching program for counseling students can reasonably be justified as a retention, persistence, progression, and graduation intervention in an online university context. The review proceeds in five steps: (1) define outcomes precisely; (2) identify the strongest general predictors of student retention and graduation in U.S. higher education; (3) assess the specific evidence for faculty relationships, mentoring, advising, coaching, belonging, and perceived institutional support; (4) examine population-specific evidence for online, graduate, adult, nontraditional, and counseling students; and (5) translate the evidence into a local evaluation and ROI framework.

Inclusion and Exclusion Criteria

Included sources were Tier 1 evidence: peer-reviewed journal articles, meta-analyses, systematic reviews, seminal scholarly books and handbooks, and major evidence reviews. Tier 2 sources---government or major nonprofit higher education reports---were used only for contextual statistics or practice guidance, primarily from the National Student Clearinghouse Research Center, the National Center for Education Statistics, and the What Works Clearinghouse. Priority was given to U.S. higher education studies published approximately within the last 10--15 years, while retaining foundational works where necessary to explain the theoretical basis of retention research.

Excluded or minimized sources included blogs, vendor whitepapers, marketing content, opinion essays, tertiary web summaries, and unsupported commentary. International studies were included only when the construct was highly transferable and U.S.-specific evidence was limited; such studies are labeled as international evidence.

Key Theories and Constructs

The review is anchored in Tinto's model of student departure, Astin's theory of student involvement, Bean and Metzner's model of nontraditional student attrition, Pascarella and Terenzini's synthesis of college impact research, Kuh's student engagement and high-impact practices framework, Strayhorn's sense of belonging theory, Bandura's self-efficacy theory, and the Community of Inquiry framework for online learning. Central constructs include academic integration, social integration, student--faculty interaction, mentoring, advising, coaching, instructor presence, perceived institutional support, belonging, mattering, engagement, self-efficacy, anxiety, help-seeking, identity, and institutional commitment.

Assumptions

This review assumes that the program under consideration is a structured, faculty-led, individualized support intervention for counseling students struggling with counseling microskills and related professional skill development. It also assumes that university leadership is making a continuation decision under cost pressure and therefore needs a rigorous distinction between claims that are directly supported by evidence and claims that are reasonable but indirect inferences from adjacent literatures.

Likely Limitations in the Evidence Base

The evidence base is stronger for retention predictors in general, for advising and mentoring, for belonging, and for online learner persistence than it is for counseling-specific faculty-led skills coaching. Most studies of mentoring, support, and belonging are observational or quasi-experimental; only some belonging interventions and a smaller number of coaching interventions have randomized evidence. Many studies examine bundled supports, making it difficult to isolate the unique effect of coaching alone. Definitions of retention, persistence, stop-out, completion, and graduation vary across studies, which limits direct comparability.

Where Direct Evidence Is Limited

Direct evidence on "faculty-led skills coaching for counseling microskills" is sparse. Therefore, this whitepaper distinguishes among: (a) direct evidence on coaching, mentoring, advising, or belonging interventions that affect retention or progression; (b) population-specific direct evidence on online, graduate, adult, nontraditional, and counseling-related learners; and (c) adjacent evidence from doctoral advising, clinical training, online instructor presence, graduate coaching, and health professions education that supports a plausible mechanism but does not by itself prove causal effects for this exact program model.

Executive Summary

The strongest available evidence supports a clear but bounded conclusion: student retention, persistence, and graduation in higher education are shaped not only by academic performance and financial factors, but also by the quality of students' relationships with faculty and staff, their sense of belonging, their perception that the institution supports them, and the presence of sustained, personalized academic support. Across the literature, these relational and support constructs are repeatedly associated with whether students remain enrolled, progress efficiently, and complete credentials.

Five decades of retention scholarship, spanning multiple theoretical traditions, meta-analyses, and randomized trials, converge on a consistent finding: meaningful faculty contact, individualized support, perceived institutional care, and the sense of belonging these interactions create are among the strongest *modifiable* predictors of student retention, persistence, and degree completion---especially for online, graduate, adult, and nontraditional learners (Tinto, 2012; Strayhorn, 2019; Kuh, 2008; Robbins et al., 2004). While effect sizes for any single intervention are typically small to moderate, the cumulative evidence indicates that structured coaching programs activate multiple empirically validated retention mechanisms simultaneously.

For the specific question facing leadership, the evidence supports continuing a faculty-led skills coaching program as a plausible student success intervention, especially in an online graduate counseling context, while evaluating it rigorously rather than treating its value as self-evident. The most defensible institutional claim is not that faculty-led skills coaching has been proven to cause higher graduation rates in counseling students specifically. Rather, the program targets mechanisms that the higher education literature consistently identifies as relevant to persistence and completion, these mechanisms may be especially consequential for online, graduate, adult, and nontraditional learners, and discontinuing a high-

touch support program without local outcome testing would ignore a substantial and convergent body of evidence on what helps students stay and succeed.

Problem Statement

Student attrition, stop-out, delayed progression, and extended time-to-degree remain persistent challenges in U.S. higher education. The National Student Clearinghouse Research Center (2025) reports that the national six-year college completion rate for fall 2019 starters was 61.1%, and the second-fall persistence rate for fall 2023 starters was 77.6%. National data from NCES reveal that 64% of first-time, full-time students at four-year institutions graduate within six years---63% at public institutions, 68% at private nonprofits, and 29% at private for-profits. Online programs face significantly higher attrition, with dropout rates documented at 25--40% versus 10--20% for on-campus programs (Levy, 2007; Muljana & Luo, 2019). Graduate student attrition is a "hidden crisis" (Lovitts & Nelson, 2000): 30--50% of doctoral students never complete, with rates highest in humanities and professional programs (Nerad & Miller, 1996). The majority of undergraduate departures occur during the first year; graduate attrition concentrates in the first year and the dissertation/clinical stage (Tinto, 1993; Bowen & Rudenstine, 1992).

These challenges are often more acute among online learners, graduate students, adult learners, and students with substantial work or family obligations. In such settings, leaders frequently question whether high-touch, labor-intensive supports justify their cost. Faculty-led skills coaching programs are particularly vulnerable to scrutiny because they require scarce faculty time and are sometimes perceived as individualized remediation rather than institutional infrastructure.

For counseling programs, the issue is especially consequential. Students are not only completing coursework; they are developing professional competencies, clinical identity, and interpersonal skills required for progression into practicum, internship, and the profession. Struggles with counseling microskills may trigger anxiety, reduced self-efficacy, loss of belonging, delayed progression, and withdrawal. The institutional question is whether a structured faculty-led coaching response to such struggles can reasonably be justified as a student success investment.

This whitepaper addresses that question by distinguishing among key outcome terms:

- **Retention**: continued enrollment at the same institution from one period to the next.
- **Persistence**: continued progress toward the credential, whether or not the student remains at the same institution.
- **Stop-out**: a temporary interruption in enrollment, distinguished from permanent dropout.
- **Graduation/Completion**: earning the intended credential.
- **Time-to-degree**: elapsed time from initial enrollment to degree conferral.

These are related but distinct outcomes. A program may improve short-term persistence without materially affecting graduation, or improve progression efficiency without changing initial retention. The evidence should therefore be interpreted with outcome specificity.

Research Questions

1. What are the strongest predictors of student retention, persistence, graduation, and shorter time-to-degree in U.S. higher education?
2. To what extent do faculty relationships, mentoring, coaching, advising, instructor presence, and perceived institutional support predict these outcomes?
3. How important are sense of belonging, mattering, academic integration, social integration, and student engagement?
4. What does the literature specifically say about online students, graduate students, counseling students, adult learners, and nontraditional students?
5. Is there evidence that a structured support program such as faculty-led skills coaching could reasonably improve retention or graduation-related outcomes?
6. Through what mechanisms might such a program work, such as increased self-efficacy, reduced anxiety, greater belonging, stronger academic identity, more clarity, or stronger institutional commitment?
7. What are the strongest counterarguments, limitations, and unresolved questions?

8. Based on the literature, what should be measured locally to evaluate whether a skills coaching program is worth keeping?

Method and Evidence Standards

This whitepaper draws primarily on peer-reviewed journal articles, meta-analyses, systematic reviews, landmark theoretical works, and major evidence reviews. Contextual statistics were drawn from the National Student Clearinghouse Research Center and NCES. Practice recommendations on advising and coaching were drawn from the What Works Clearinghouse (WWC) guide on effective advising for postsecondary students, which synthesizes studies meeting WWC standards and provides evidence-based recommendations for comprehensive, integrated advising to support student success (What Works Clearinghouse, 2024).

The review applies source-specific interpretive standards:

- Correlational evidence is treated as evidence of association or prediction, not proof of causation.
- Quasi-experimental evidence is treated as stronger than cross-sectional association but still subject to selection effects.
- Randomized evidence is treated as the strongest basis for causal inference, though generalizability still matters.
- Counseling-specific claims are marked as direct only when supported within counseling or closely related clinical training populations; otherwise they are identified as adjacent inference.

When judging evidence strength, the whitepaper uses only these labels: **Strongly supported**, **Moderately supported**, **Limited but promising**, and **Uncertain or mixed**.

Theoretical Foundations

Tinto's Interactionalist Theory of Student Departure

Vincent Tinto's model of student departure (1975, 1993) holds near-paradigmatic status in retention research, with over 775 citations and more than 170 dissertation tests by the late 1990s (Braxton et al., 1997). The core proposition is that students who achieve higher levels of academic integration (intellectual engagement, faculty interaction, academic performance) and social integration (peer interaction, campus involvement) develop stronger institutional and goal commitments, reducing dropout probability. However, Braxton et al.'s (1997) systematic assessment found robust empirical support for only 5 of 13 primary propositions, with social integration better supported than academic integration. The model has been criticized for cultural bias favoring White, residential, traditional-age students (Tierney, 1992; Guiffrida, 2006), for implying students must "separate" from prior communities (Rendón, 1994), and for limited applicability to commuter, online, and nontraditional populations (Davidson & Wilson, 2013).

Tinto himself evolved significantly. In *Completing College* (2012), he shifted from explaining why students leave to prescribing what institutions must do, identifying four institutional conditions: high expectations, academic and social support, frequent assessment and feedback, and active involvement. These four conditions map directly onto what a structured coaching program provides. For the present case, Tinto matters because faculty-led coaching may strengthen academic integration by clarifying expectations, providing feedback, and helping students see a pathway forward when they are struggling.

Bean and Metzner's Model of Nontraditional Student Attrition

Bean and Metzner (1985) developed their model specifically because Tinto's framework failed to account for nontraditional students---older, part-time, commuter students. Their central insight: for nontraditional students, environmental factors (finances, work hours, family responsibilities, outside encouragement) are more important than social integration in predicting attrition, and psychological outcomes (satisfaction, goal commitment, stress) mediate the effect of institutional experiences on persistence. Most critically for this analysis, their model demonstrates that social integration has minimal to no effect on adult learner persistence; retention for this demographic is driven almost entirely by academic variables and the perceived instrumental utility of the coursework.

This framework is directly relevant to online counseling students, who are typically adult learners (25+) juggling employment, family, and school. NCES data show students aged 25 and older are six times more likely to have dependents and 78% more likely to attend part-time (Rose et al., 2024). Cabrera et al. (1992) found that integrating Tinto's and Bean's models explained persistence better than either alone.

Astin's Theory of Student Involvement

Alexander Astin's Theory of Student Involvement (1984, 1993) established that students learn and persist in proportion to the physical and psychological energy they invest in their academic experience. Student--faculty interaction is one critical channel through which such involvement is fostered. The relevance is that individualized coaching may increase active investment, accountability, and engagement for students who are beginning to disengage.

Pascarella and Terenzini's College Impact Synthesis

Pascarella and Terenzini's massive three-volume synthesis *How College Affects Students* (1991, 2005), spanning thousands of studies and over 3,000 references, confirmed that within-college effects matter more than between-college effects: what happens to students during college is more important than which institution they attend. They established that informal, non-classroom interactions with faculty positively influence persistence, educational aspirations, and intellectual development. They also demonstrated that effects are often cumulative and modest at the level of any single experience---important for interpreting the present program: a faculty-led coaching intervention may not produce dramatic effects by itself, but it may contribute meaningfully as part of a broader ecology of student success.

Kuh's Student Engagement and High-Impact Practices

George Kuh's work on High-Impact Practices (2008) through the National Survey of Student Engagement (NSSE) identified that activities sharing certain characteristics---meaningful faculty/peer interaction, frequent substantive feedback, high expectations, application of learning, and reflection---produce the strongest effects on retention and graduation, with benefits especially pronounced for historically underserved students and academically underprepared students. For underprepared students, robust engagement has a powerful compensatory effect, offsetting the risks of lower initial academic skills (Kuh, 2008). Faculty-led coaching resembles the logic of high-impact support in that it is relationship-based, feedback-rich, and structured around engagement rather than passive referral.

Strayhorn's Sense of Belonging and Schlossberg's Mattering

Terrell Strayhorn's (2012, 2019) belonging framework established that students' perceived social support, connectedness, and feeling of mattering constitute a basic human need that, when unmet, directly impairs retention, achievement, and well-being. Belonging is not a vague sentiment; it is a meaningful predictor of persistence, engagement, and well-being that becomes especially salient in certain contexts (transitions, unfamiliar environments) and for certain populations (marginalized groups, online learners).

Nancy Schlossberg's (1989) adjacent concept of "mattering" focuses on a student's perception that they are individually noticed, cared about, and valued by specific institutional representatives. The distinction matters for online students: belonging implies broad integration into a community, while mattering refers to being individually valued by specific people. For online and post-traditional students who inherently lack physical campus connections, mattering may be a far more critical and actionable construct than broad belonging. When a faculty coach demonstrates individual investment in a student's improvement, they are activating mattering directly.

Community of Inquiry Framework and Online Retention Scholars

For online learners, Garrison, Anderson, and Archer's (2000) Community of Inquiry (CoI) framework identifies three interdependent presences: teaching presence (design, facilitation, direct instruction), social presence (open communication, cohesion, affect), and cognitive presence (inquiry stages). Within online contexts, instructor/teaching presence is heavily correlated with perceived learning, student satisfaction, and persistence. Boston et al. (2009), analyzing over 28,000 student records, found that social presence indicators accounted for a significant portion of variance in re-enrollment---the first large-scale empirical link between CoI and retention.

Moore's (1997) Transactional Distance Theory predicts that the greater the perceived psychological distance between learner and instructor, the greater the risk of disengagement and dropout. Rovai's (2003) Composite Persistence Model for online learners explicitly integrates academic and social integration, self-esteem, goal commitment, and learning community. These frameworks matter because faculty-led coaching may function as a high-touch substitute for the informal support cues that online students otherwise lack.

Literature Review

Retention and Persistence Theories

The retention literature consistently shows that student departure is multi-causal. No single factor explains attrition across all contexts. Academic performance remains one of the strongest immediate predictors, but relational, psychological, and structural factors shape whether students recover from difficulty or disengage after it. Tinto's integration model, Astin's involvement theory, Bean and Metzner's nontraditional attrition model, and later engagement and belonging frameworks all converge on a common point: persistence is not merely an individual trait; it is partly produced through the interaction between the student and the institution (Astin, 1984; Bean & Metzner, 1985; Tinto, 1993, 2012; Kuh, 2008).

This matters for leadership decisions because it reframes faculty-led support as part of the institution's design, not simply a service students may or may not use. If persistence is institutionally mediated, then eliminating a high-touch support mechanism is an intervention in its own right.

Academic Integration and Social Integration

Academic integration refers to the student's connection to the academic life of the institution: competence, feedback, intellectual engagement, clarity of expectations, and sense of fit. Social integration refers to connection with peers, faculty, and the broader community. The literature suggests both matter, but their relative importance varies by setting.

In residential undergraduate environments, both are predictive. In adult, commuter, and online environments, academic integration tends to be more consistently relevant than traditional notions of social integration (Bean & Metzner, 1985; Muljana & Luo, 2019). For graduate and professional students, academic integration is often enacted through advisor or faculty relationships, program fit, and disciplinary identity rather than through broad campus belonging. The evidence is **Strongly supported** that for traditional residential undergraduates, a balance of both forms is required. However, for online and adult learners, social integration shows minimal to no significant effect on stop-out or dropout intentions; academic integration, task-relevant support, and course utility drive persistence.

For a counseling skills coaching program, the most relevant implication is that students who struggle with microskills may experience a rupture in academic integration. They may question whether they can meet the program's expectations, whether they belong in the profession, and whether the institution can help them succeed. Coaching may work less by "socializing" students in the traditional sense and more by restoring academic fit, confidence, and commitment.

Sense of Belonging and Mattering

Belonging has one of the strongest evidence bases among the relational and psychological constructs reviewed here. Using nationally representative U.S. data (N = 23,750), Gopalan and Brady (2020) found that first-year students' sense of belonging at four-year institutions predicted later persistence, service use, and mental health even after covariate adjustment. A recent twenty-year systematic review concluded that belonging affects academic engagement, motivation, persistence, and achievement (Allen et al., 2024). Dias-Broens et al. (2024), reviewing 150 studies, specifically linked belonging to academic performance, mental health, and well-being.

The causal case is strengthened by randomized trials. Walton and Cohen (2011) showed that a brief social-belonging intervention improved academic and health outcomes for minoritized students. Murphy et al. (2020) found that a customized belonging intervention improved one-year and two-year retention for socially disadvantaged students at a broad-access institution. Broda et al. (2018) found similar results with belonging interventions for incoming college students. Strayhorn (2019) notes that belonging takes on heightened importance in certain contexts and for certain populations---conditions that describe online counseling students precisely.

For online learners specifically, Rovai and colleagues found that online students feel weaker connectedness and belonging than on-campus students. Isolation is described as one of the biggest impediments to learning, satisfaction, and success in online environments (Blackmon & Major, 2012; Zhao & You, 2024). Faculty who create responsive environments play a central role in helping students feel seen.

Faculty Interaction, Mentoring, Advising, and Coaching

The evidence on faculty contact, mentoring, coaching, and advising as retention interventions converges from multiple meta-analyses and rigorous studies. Effect sizes are typically small to moderate for any individual intervention, but they are consistent, replicated, and---critically---target malleable institutional behaviors rather than fixed student characteristics.

Meta-analytic evidence. Sneyers and De Witte (2018) meta-analyzed 25 quasi-experimental studies in higher education and found that student--faculty mentoring produced a positive effect on retention (d = 0.15) and graduation (d = 0.10), translating to approximately an 8% improvement in retention and a 5% improvement in graduation. Eby et al. (2008), in a multidisciplinary meta-analysis in the *Journal of Vocational Behavior*, found mentoring is associated with favorable behavioral, attitudinal, and career outcomes, with larger effects in academic and workplace mentoring than youth mentoring, though the overall effect size is generally small (d = 0.08--0.09). Robbins et al.'s (2004) major meta-analysis in *Psychological Bulletin* (109 studies) quantified psychosocial predictors: academic self-efficacy correlated with retention at $\rho = .359$ and with GPA at $\rho = .496$; academic goals at $\rho = .340$; academic-related skills at $\rho = .366$. These psychosocial factors provided incremental predictive validity beyond SES, standardized test scores, and high school GPA. Schneider and Preckel's (2017) meta-meta-analysis, synthesizing 38 meta-analyses across approximately 2 million students, found self-efficacy effects as high as ES = 1.81, among the largest of all 105 correlates examined.

Quality of interaction matters. Not just any contact with faculty helps. Loes et al. (2024) found that the quality of student--faculty interactions---not mere frequency---more strongly predicts persistence, echoing longstanding scholarly arguments. The WWC advising guide (2024) takes this further by treating advising as a core institutional function, assigning **Strong evidence** to transforming advising around sustained, personalized relationships and **Strong evidence** to using mentoring and coaching to support student achievement and progression.

Randomized and quasi-experimental evidence. Bettinger and Baker (2014) evaluated InsideTrack coaching in a large-scale RCT (N = 13,555 across 17 cohorts) and found that coached students were significantly more likely to persist both during and after coaching, with coached students approximately 5 percentage points more likely to persist at 12 months. The WWC intervention report confirmed a 66.4% retention rate for coached students versus 61.4% for controls, with a statistically significant improvement index (WWC, 2017). Alzen et al. (2021) found in a quasi-experimental study at the University of Colorado Boulder that coached students with prior GPAs of 1.0--2.0 earned GPAs approximately 0.4 points higher, were approximately 10% more likely to re-enroll, and earned approximately two more credits in the subsequent semester. Barr and Castleman (2021) found that intensive advising led to large increases in bachelor's degree attainment, with College Forward advising increasing five-year bachelor's completion by 6.5 percentage points---a 32% relative increase.

The most dramatic effect belongs to CUNY's Accelerated Study in Associate Programs (ASAP), a comprehensive support model combining intensive advising, tutoring, career development, and financial support. MDRC's RCT---the largest positive effect in over 30 RCT evaluations of community college interventions since 2003---showed ASAP raised three-year graduation rates by 18 percentage points (53.4% vs. 24.6%), replicated in Ohio at 16 percentage points (Scrivener et al., 2015). Students consistently cited personalized advisement as the most central component.

Thomas (2020) found that intrusive advising for developmental course students produced pass rates of 49.3% versus 33.7%, a 46.5% relative increase.

Student Engagement and Involvement

Engagement reflects behavioral participation, cognitive investment, and emotional connection to learning. Xue and Li's (2023) meta-analysis found that engagement is shaped by both internal factors such as self-efficacy and external factors such as teacher support and course design. Kuh's engagement literature positions student--faculty interaction and enriching educational experiences as important to success (Kuh, 2008). For skills coaching, engagement matters in two ways: coaching may increase engagement by making expectations clearer and reducing avoidance, and students who attend coaching may signal help-seeking and commitment that can be reinforced. However, selection effects are a concern; students who opt in may differ from those who do not.

Online Learner Retention

Online learners warrant special attention because the program context is an online university. In a systematic review, Muljana and Luo (2019) identified institutional support, sense of belonging, facilitation of learning, and course design among the major contributors to online retention. Hart (2012) found that online persistence is associated with satisfaction, belonging to the learning community, motivation, support, and increased communication with the instructor. Lee and Choi (2011) grouped dropout factors into student, course/program, and environmental categories. A recent systematic review of online academic student support confirms that support structures are core conditions for persistence, not peripheral add-ons (Walsh et al., 2024). Lubis et al. (2025) found in a systematic review that perceived teacher support is consistently associated with student engagement, often through self-efficacy, motivation, and psychological need fulfillment.

Instructor interaction is identified as the second-highest retention factor in online learning (Heyman, 2010). Gallien and Oomen-Early (2008) found that personalized instructor feedback enhanced both student satisfaction and perceived connectedness. Online student self-efficacy is identified as the most influential factor linked to retention (Ivankova & Stick, 2007), and skills coaching directly builds self-efficacy through what Bandura (1986, 1997) identified as the most powerful source: mastery experiences with supportive feedback.

The implication is direct: in online programs, high-touch human support may carry more weight, not less, because students lack many ambient cues of support. A faculty-led coaching program can function as a deliberately constructed form of institutional presence.

Adult and Nontraditional Learner Retention

Adult and nontraditional students often balance work, caregiving, and financial responsibilities alongside study. Bean and Metzner's model predicted that environmental pressures loom larger for these students than traditional campus social integration, and contemporary evidence continues to support that view. What matters most is not generalized campus involvement but timely, personalized academic support; flexible structures; help navigating institutional systems; and a sense that the institution sees them as legitimate students despite competing demands. This is where mattering and academic integration intersect.

The limitation is important: coaching is unlikely to fully offset structural barriers when financial strain, employment intensity, or caregiving demands are severe. In adult-serving institutions, coaching should be understood as one lever among several, not a substitute for flexible policy and broader student supports.

Graduate Student Retention

The graduate retention literature places unusually strong weight on advisor and faculty relationships. The advisor-advisee relationship is the single most recurrent predictor of completion in graduate education (Bair & Haworth, 1999). Lovitts (2001), in the seminal *Leaving the Ivory Tower*, found that completers felt their advisors were significantly more interested in them than non-completers, and shifted the blame narrative from individual student deficits to institutional and programmatic failures. Hurtado et al. (2024)

found that supervisor relationships, self-efficacy, motivation, well-being, and integration with faculty and peers are prominent predictors of doctoral persistence. Dewald-Wang et al. (2024) found that frequent one-on-one meetings, empathetic and constructive feedback, and multiple mentoring relationships predicted student success and belonging in biological sciences doctoral students. Land et al. (2014) identified mentoring as a best practice in doctoral retention.

Graduate students often experience departure risk at points of identity and performance crisis rather than only at points of poor grades. Coaching may matter because it addresses uncertainty, self-efficacy, feedback interpretation, and role clarity---the kinds of ambiguity that make capable graduate students feel they are failing. Mental health concerns are prevalent: Evans et al. (2018) documented chronic stress and mental health challenges among graduate students. A structured coaching intervention that maintains regular faculty contact, provides formative feedback, and normalizes struggle directly counteracts the isolation and self-blame dynamics that drive graduate attrition.

Counseling Student and Clinical Skill Development Implications

The evidence for counseling students specifically is more limited than the broader graduate and online evidence, but it is not empty. CACREP 2024 Standards (Section 1.O) require programs to maintain policies for student retention, remediation, and dismissal. Dixon-Saxon and Buckley (2020) identified community building, faculty presence, and student engagement as key factors in distance counselor education retention. Jensen (2018) found that a first-year social integration program for master's counseling students was associated with higher reported retention than a control cohort, explicitly designed to increase integration with both students and faculty.

Counseling self-efficacy (CSE) develops across training in a well-documented trajectory. Mullen et al. (2015) found that master's-level counselors-in-training increased from a mean CSE of 57.09 at orientation to 83.04 at final internship. Larson and Daniels's (1998) seminal integrative review established that CSE is shaped by Bandura's four sources: mastery experiences, vicarious learning, verbal persuasion (feedback), and physiological/affective state management. Daniels and Larson (2001) demonstrated that positive feedback significantly increased CSE and decreased anxiety, while negative feedback decreased CSE and increased anxiety---establishing the direct mechanism through which coaching affects self-efficacy.

The Deliberate Practice Coaching Framework proposed by Irvine et al. (2024) integrates five tasks---self-assessment, skill repetition, formative feedback, stretch goals, and progress monitoring---plus peer mentoring. A randomized controlled trial of deliberate practice in clinical training found that the DP group significantly increased communication skills and reported significantly greater self-efficacy than the control group (cited in Irvine et al., 2024). Donaldson et al. (2025), in a systematic scoping review of academic coaching in graduate healthcare and medical education, found that coaching interventions improve learner development, self-regulation, and resilience.

The gatekeeping literature further supports coaching. Gaubatz and Vera (2002) found that approximately 10% of counselors-in-training are not suited for the profession, but only half experienced remediation---significant "gateslipping." Rose and Persutte-Manning (2020) found that students with problems of professional competency exact a negative toll on proficient students. A structured coaching program serves dual purposes: proactive competency building and appropriate early gatekeeping.

Psychological and Behavioral Mechanisms

The evidence supports an integrated pathway model through which coaching affects retention:

Coaching → Self-Efficacy → Persistence. Self-efficacy is among the strongest psychosocial predictors of retention ($\rho = .359$; Robbins et al., 2004; ES = 1.81; Schneider & Preckel, 2017). Bandura's (1986, 1997) theory identifies four sources: performance accomplishments, vicarious learning, verbal persuasion, and physiological state management. A skills coaching program provides the first three directly. Lent et al.'s (1994) Social Cognitive Career Theory confirms that students with higher self-efficacy persist longer in the face of setbacks.

Coaching → Belonging and Mattering → Institutional Commitment → Retention. Schlossberg's (1989) theory posits that every role transition creates potential for feeling marginal, and mattering promotes involvement and persistence. Hausmann et al. (2007) demonstrated that sense of belonging predicted intentions to persist. For online students, individualized faculty contact may be the primary---sometimes only---source of institutional belonging. When adult learners feel they matter to a specific faculty member, their likelihood of persistence increases significantly, even in the face of external pressures.

Coaching → Academic Integration → Goal Commitment → Completion. In Tinto's framework, academic integration strengthens goal and institutional commitment. For graduate students, academic integration matters more than social integration (Braxton et al., 2004). Coaching sessions focused on skill development constitute a direct form of academic integration.

Coaching → Professional Identity → Persistence. Gibson et al. (2010) identified transformational tasks in counselor professional identity development. Woo and Henfield (2015) confirmed developmental progression using the Professional Identity Scale in Counseling. A coaching program that builds counseling skills simultaneously builds professional identity, strengthening the student's investment in completing the degree.

Coaching → Anxiety Reduction → Academic Performance → Retention. Trusty et al. (2025), in a six-year cohort study at Penn State (N = 190,907), found that academic distress at the beginning of counseling significantly predicted academic dropout. Daniels and Larson (2001) demonstrated the direct CSE-anxiety link in counseling trainees.

Contradictions, Mixed Findings, and Cautions

Not all evidence is equally strong. Several counterarguments deserve serious consideration.

Effect sizes are small to moderate. Faculty mentoring produces $d = 0.15$ on retention (Sneyers & De Witte, 2018); general mentoring effects average $d = 0.08$--0.09 (Eby et al., 2008). However, small effects compound meaningfully when multiplied across cohorts and years of revenue.

Self-selection bias is the largest methodological threat. Students who voluntarily engage with coaching may already be more motivated. Only a handful of studies---Bettinger and Baker (2014), the CUNY ASAP RCT---meet the gold standard of randomized assignment.

Tinto's model has documented weaknesses. Only 5 of 13 propositions received robust support (Braxton et al., 1997). Cultural critiques (Tierney, 1992; Guiffrida, 2006) argue the "integration" concept can mask assimilationist assumptions.

The persistence-completion gap. While Bettinger and Baker (2014) observed significant retention gains at 12 months, effects on ultimate degree attainment were not statistically significant at 24 months, suggesting coaching effects may wane without sustained engagement or "booster" sessions. Many effective programs (CUNY ASAP) bundle multiple supports, complicating isolation of any single component.

Dose-response matters. Alonso García et al. (2025; N = 9,063; international evidence) found that four or more mentoring sessions reduced dropout and improved GPA, while three or fewer sessions were insufficient. Coaching must be well-designed, adequately dosed, and personally delivered.

Alternative explanations. It is possible that any caring human contact would produce similar effects regardless of coaching content, that less expensive interventions could achieve comparable results, or that effects are concentrated among a subgroup. These questions can only be resolved through local evaluation.

Evidence Synthesis

Strongest Predictors

The strongest predictors of retention and graduation remain academic performance, financial stability, academic integration, and---in many settings---belonging and perceived support. However, these should not be interpreted as competing explanations. Academic performance itself is shaped by psychological and relational conditions. Students perform better and persist longer when they experience clearer expectations, stronger support, and a greater sense they can succeed.

The most policy-relevant finding is that faculty relationships, mentoring, advising, coaching, and belonging are not merely correlates sitting beside the "real" drivers. They often act as mechanisms through which students remain engaged long enough to recover from academic or personal difficulty.

Most Consistent Findings

Several findings are especially consistent:

- Belonging predicts persistence, especially at four-year institutions and among disadvantaged students (**Strongly supported**).

- Sustained, personalized advising is better supported than transactional advising (**Strongly supported**).
- Mentoring and coaching can improve near-term progression and persistence (**Moderately supported**).
- Online learners depend heavily on instructor presence and institutional support (**Strongly supported**).
- Graduate and doctoral learners are particularly sensitive to faculty or supervisor relationship quality (**Strongly supported**).
- Adult and nontraditional learners need support that acknowledges external barriers and emphasizes academic navigation rather than traditional campus social integration (**Strongly supported**).

Likely Mechanisms

The most plausible mechanisms for a faculty-led skills coaching program are: increased self-efficacy through guided practice and feedback; reduced anxiety and threat interpretation after difficulty; stronger academic integration through clearer standards and improvement pathways; increased belonging and mattering through personalized faculty attention; greater institutional commitment because students perceive the institution as invested; improved help-seeking and earlier intervention before difficulties escalate; and strengthened professional identity.

Where Evidence Is Direct versus Indirect

Direct evidence is strongest for: belonging interventions and persistence; mentoring and coaching as supports for postsecondary progression; sustained personalized advising; online retention factors involving support, design, and instructor presence; and doctoral retention and advisor quality.

Indirect but persuasive evidence supports the case that faculty-led coaching for counseling students may improve retention-related outcomes through mechanisms established in adjacent literatures: graduate advising, online teaching presence, mentoring, health professions coaching, and counseling doctoral mentoring. This is persuasive because the intervention targets the same mechanisms the broader literature repeatedly identifies, even if the exact intervention label differs.

What the Evidence Most Strongly Supports

1. Retention and completion are shaped by more than grades and finances. Relationship-based support, belonging, and institutional responsiveness matter.
2. Personalized, sustained advising and mentoring are better supported than minimal or transactional support.
3. Online and graduate contexts increase the importance of intentional human connection because students have fewer informal opportunities to receive support.
4. Coaching is most clearly supported as a persistence and progression intervention. Evidence for graduation is positive but less definitive, especially when coaching is isolated from broader support systems.
5. For counseling students, the exact intervention under review has limited direct evidence, but it targets mechanisms that are highly plausible and well supported in adjacent literatures.
6. Proactive, individualized academic coaching increases short- to medium-term retention rates by a statistically significant margin compared to un-coached controls (**Strongly supported**).
7. Adult and online learners prioritize academic integration, task-relevant support, and course utility over social integration (**Strongly supported**).
8. Mastery experiences, coupled with supportive expert feedback, are the primary drivers in constructing Counseling Self-Efficacy (**Moderately supported**).

What Still Needs to Be Tested Locally

Several claims should not be assumed without local evaluation:

- Whether this specific faculty-led coaching model improves term-to-term retention in the local program.

- Whether the program improves practicum and internship progression rather than only immediate confidence.
- Whether coached students graduate at higher rates or complete faster than comparable non-coached students.
- Which students benefit most: those with early skills struggles, later-stage students, online students with low belonging, adult learners with external barriers, or some combination.
- What dosage, timing, and referral criteria produce the strongest outcomes.
- Whether the marginal benefits justify the faculty labor cost compared with alternative support designs.
- Whether short-term self-efficacy gains translate into sustained persistence or merely delay stop-out by one or two terms.

Implications for a Faculty-Led Skills Coaching Program

Based on the literature, a faculty-led skills coaching program can reasonably be framed as a retention and student success intervention rather than merely remediation, but the framing should be precise and restrained.

The strongest argument is that the program addresses the points at which student departure often begins. A student struggling with counseling microskills is at risk not only of poor performance, but of decreased self-efficacy, heightened anxiety, delayed practicum readiness, threatened professional identity, and reduced institutional commitment. Coaching can plausibly interrupt that sequence by providing targeted feedback, a recovery plan, and a relational signal that the institution is invested in the student's development.

This framing is particularly credible in an online university environment. Online learners often experience lower ambient connection and greater need for visible instructor presence and institutional support. Faculty-led coaching may serve a dual role: skill development and institutional connection.

The case for faculty-led rather than generic staff-led coaching. Counseling microskills are discipline-specific. Students may place more trust in feedback from faculty who understand professional competency expectations and can situate coaching within progression milestones. Adult learners are pragmatic; psychological validation carries significantly more weight in building self-efficacy when it comes from a credentialed expert rather than a generalist (Bandura, 1997). This does not mean faculty-only delivery is always superior, but it suggests a plausible value-add of discipline-specific coaching.

The limits of the inference should be stated plainly. The literature does not justify a categorical claim that any faculty-led coaching program will raise graduation rates. It supports a more measured statement: a well-designed faculty-led skills coaching program targets mechanisms meaningfully associated with retention and progression, and such a program is therefore a reasonable student success investment that merits continuation with rigorous evaluation.

Recommended Evaluation Framework

A mixed-method evaluation should be built around proximal, medium-term, and distal outcomes. The evaluation design should treat the program as a student success intervention with a theory of change, link session-level outcomes to institutional outcomes over time, compare coached students with reasonable non-coached or later-coached comparison groups, analyze both impact and cost, and disaggregate results by student type.

Possible Comparison Group Strategies

If random assignment is feasible and ethically acceptable, a wait-list design is preferable: eligible students randomly assigned to immediate or delayed coaching when demand exceeds capacity. If randomization is not feasible, use a quasi-experimental comparison: students referred as eligible who did not receive coaching due to scheduling or capacity limits; historical matched cohorts before the current model was implemented; or propensity-score or regression-adjusted comparisons using baseline risk indicators.

Simple ROI Logic

Estimate: Net program value = (incremental retained tuition attributable to improved persistence) + (avoided costs from reduced repeat coursework or delayed progression) − (faculty labor cost and administrative costs). Use conservative assumptions. Literature models demonstrate that relatively modest investments yielding even moderate retention improvements can generate retained tuition revenue exceeding program costs (Cuseo, 2010; Scrivener et al., 2015).

Recommended End-of-Session Questionnaire

Immediate Post-Session Items (1--2 minutes)

5-point scale from Strongly disagree to Strongly agree unless noted.

1. I am clearer about what skill or performance issue I need to work on next.
2. I feel more confident that I can improve this area.
3. I know the next step I should take before my next class, practice opportunity, or milestone.
4. This session made me feel supported by the program or university.
5. I feel less anxious or overwhelmed about this issue than I did before the session.
6. Because of this session, I am more likely to stay engaged in the program.
7. How helpful was this session overall? (1 = Not at all helpful to 5 = Extremely helpful)
8. What is the most useful thing you are taking away from this session? (open-ended)

Follow-Up Questionnaire (4--6 Weeks Later)

1. Since the coaching session, I have used the action plan we discussed.
2. Since the coaching session, I feel more confident in this skill area.
3. Since the coaching session, I feel more connected to faculty or program support.
4. The coaching session helped me continue moving forward in the program.
5. What, if anything, still feels unresolved? (open-ended)

Discussion

The literature supports a balanced conclusion.

What can be claimed with confidence: Retention and completion are influenced by relationship-based and support-based institutional practices, not just by student inputs. Belonging, sustained advising, mentoring, coaching, instructor presence, and perceived institutional support each have meaningful evidence bases. A faculty-led skills coaching program for counseling students is aligned with several of the strongest supported mechanisms in the student success literature. For online graduate counseling students, the convergence of multiple vulnerability factors---online modality (higher baseline attrition), graduate-level training (hidden crisis of attrition), nontraditional/adult status (competing life demands), and clinical skill requirements (performance anxiety, self-efficacy demands)---makes high-touch faculty support especially defensible.

What cannot be claimed: That this specific program has been proven to improve graduation or time-to-degree for counseling students in this local setting. The direct evidence for counseling microskills coaching is sparse, and many effective support interventions are bundled. It would be an overstatement to present the program as a guaranteed graduation lever.

What can reasonably be inferred: Discontinuing the program would remove a support structure that targets known risk mechanisms precisely where students are vulnerable: low confidence, performance anxiety, ambiguity, threatened belonging, and weakened academic integration. In an online graduate counseling environment, those mechanisms are highly plausible pathways to stop-out, delayed progression, or departure.

The appropriate decision is not blind continuation forever, nor abrupt elimination based on cost alone. It is continuation with disciplined evaluation.

Conclusion

The evidence reviewed here supports a restrained but affirmative conclusion: faculty and staff connection, mentoring, advising, belonging, and perceived institutional support are meaningful predictors of student persistence and completion in U.S. higher education, and they appear especially relevant in contexts where students are academically vulnerable, geographically dispersed, or balancing substantial external obligations.

No major retention framework predicts that a well-designed faculty-led coaching program would be inert or harmful. The convergence across Tinto's integration model, Bean and Metzner's nontraditional student model, Astin's involvement theory, Kuh's high-impact practices, Strayhorn's belonging framework, Garrison's Community of Inquiry, Bandura's self-efficacy theory, and Lent's Social Cognitive Career Theory is striking---each identifies mechanisms that a faculty-led skills coaching program activates.

The strongest institutional argument is empirical and pragmatic: retain the program, measure it properly, and let the data answer the ROI question. The research literature does not support discontinuing a high-touch faculty support intervention for a high-risk student population without local evaluation. It does support continuing the program with a commitment to systematic evaluation over two to three cohort cycles.

Administrator Takeaways

Five Takeaways

1. The literature does not support the view that retention is driven only by grades and finances. Belonging, sustained advising, mentoring, and faculty support are meaningful, modifiable predictors---especially for online, adult, and nontraditional learners.
2. Randomized controlled trials demonstrate that coaching interventions produce real (if modest) improvements in persistence, with Bettinger and Baker (2014) showing effects that persisted after coaching ended and Barr and Castleman (2021) finding a 32% relative increase in bachelor's attainment from intensive advising.
3. For counseling students specifically, coaching builds counseling self-efficacy through mastery experiences and feedback---the mechanisms Bandura identified as most powerful---while fulfilling CACREP-mandated gatekeeping responsibilities.

4. The dose-response literature indicates a minimum threshold of approximately four sessions for measurable dropout reduction. Program design and student engagement matter as much as program existence.
5. The financial logic is straightforward: if the program retains even a small number of students who would otherwise stop out, the tuition revenue preserved likely exceeds program costs.

Three Cautions

1. Direct evidence for "faculty-led counseling microskills coaching" as a specific intervention category is sparse. The argument relies on convergent evidence from adjacent literatures, which is persuasive but not the same as direct proof. Claims should be framed carefully.
2. Many effective support interventions are bundled (e.g., CUNY ASAP), making it difficult to isolate the effect of coaching alone. Some coaching effects on persistence do not translate into significant degree completion effects without sustained engagement.
3. No amount of academic coaching can overcome all external constraints that drive adult learner stop-out. Implementation quality and dosage determine impact. A poorly designed or insufficiently staffed program may produce no measurable effect.

Three Next-Step Recommendations

1. **Continue the program for a defined evaluation period** and reframe it explicitly as a strategic student success and retention intervention rather than a reactive remedial cost center.
2. **Implement the brief end-of-session and follow-up questionnaires immediately** and begin collecting pre/post self-efficacy data, session dosage, and satisfaction measures for the current cohort.
3. **Link coaching participation to institutional outcomes** using matched comparison or regression analyses. Partner with Institutional Research to run matched-sample historical analysis comparing persistence of coached versus non-coached students with similar baseline risk profiles. Review results annually for impact and ROI.

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